> The India-Afghanistan relationship is basically an India-Pashtun relationship ... we are all part of that generation when the Afghans used to come in the old Kabuliwallah style ... it's a living memory for most of us ... they are Pashtuns and not people from the north or Tajiks and so on.[6]

When the US-led NATO forces entered Afghanistan in 2001, a retired Indian army officer privy to policymaking claims, 'there [was] an emotional bond, the Kabuliwallah bond with the Afghans ... [in 2001] there was a romantic perception about Afghanistan [in India]. As the Americans settled down and started waging their global war on terrorism, in the light of public opinion and our historical relations with Afghanistan, we [India] decided that it was not in our interest to join [the war]. So we started doing developmental work.'[7] India's search for 'friends' may be linked both to New Delhi's rivalry with Islamabad, and its historic bonds with Afghanistan. The following sections show how this bilateral connect got tested at various moments, by offering a historical overview of India-Afghanistan relations till the Soviet invasion in 1979. By doing so, it sets the historical context whereby Indian policymakers debate their policy approach towards Afghanistan.

## *A historical bond*

Imagining India without Afghanistan, and Afghanistan without India, is impossible. Despite the phrase having become an overused diplomatic trope in contemporary South Asia, India-Afghanistan relations are truly civilisational. Historians have traced them back, at least, to the Indus Valley civilisation.[8] Having seen an invasion by 'Alexander the Great', modern day Afghanistan came under the Seleucid Empire and was ceded to Chandragupta Maurya in 305 BCE.[9] Eventually Emperor Ashoka came to rule parts of Afghanistan, introducing Buddhism to the region. The Mauryan Empire declined half a century after Ashoka's death. Leading to decades of instability, Afghanistan saw the rise of the Greco-Bactrians, then the Indo-Greek kingdoms (the Kushan Empire), and then the Indo-Scythians.[10] Islam began its advent in Afghanistan from the seventh century and spread across India between the tenth and the nineteenth century. Often taking form of violent invasions, India was conquered by a series of invaders who were based in what today has become Afghanistan.